

Unit 1: Performing Music

Overview

Content overview

In this unit students develop their performing skills in both a solo and ensemble context. They should be given the opportunity to rehearse and refine performances in their chosen discipline or genre, developing technical control, expression and interpretative skills.

This unit will encourage students to develop creative thinking, aesthetic sensitivity, critical awareness, self-confidence, self-motivation and their own musical interests and skills, including the ability to make music individually and in groups.

Assessment overview

Students will perform/realise one solo performance of their own choice in any style or genre, with or without accompaniment as appropriate to the style of music. The performance may be:

- a solo performance on any instrument
- a solo improvisation on any instrument
- a sequenced performance
- a realisation such as a performance with DJ decks/turntables or a live sound diffusion of electro-acoustic music.

Students will perform a piece in any genre or style as part of an ensemble performance. The performance may be:

- performing an undoubled part within an ensemble
- improvising as part of an ensemble
- rehearsing and directing an ensemble
- presenting a multi-track recording.

The ensemble performance may be on a different instrument/voice or in a different discipline to that of the solo performance – any combination of the various solo and ensemble performance options is acceptable.

There is no minimum duration for either performance, but pieces should be of sufficient length and complexity to give the performer adequate opportunity to showcase their abilities. Neither performance should exceed five minutes.

Students should understand the contextual influences affecting the composition of the pieces they are performing, including the composer's intentions regarding the venue and nature of the performance and any important cultural influences relating to the composition of the piece. Students should listen to how established performers communicate within their chosen style. They should appraise their own use of articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast in the light of these performances and reflect this in the interpretation of their chosen performance pieces. This wider study will enable them to access the full range of marks within the interpretation assessment grids.

Students do not need to perform pieces from the same Area of Study as their compositions. However, they may choose to perform their own compositions.

Performances may be completed at any time during the course. At an appropriate point during the course, the performances will be recorded and assessed by the teacher-examiner. At the end of the course a sample of performances must be made available for moderation on CD/MD/MP3.

Scores, recordings and written commentaries

A score or professional recording of each performance piece must be made available to the moderator. Performances that are not accompanied by acceptable scores or recordings will not be assessed.

For solo improvisation and improvising as part of an ensemble, the stimulus must be submitted in lieu of a score. For realisation, students must submit a written commentary outlining performance detail and intentions in lieu of a score.

Where changes have been made to facilitate performance, scores should be annotated. If the student's performance differs from the professional recording, any changes should be documented and presented to the moderator along with the professional recording.

Controlled conditions

Students must be supervised regularly when preparing their performances. Students have a maximum of 10 hours to complete each recording under teacher supervision.

Reference should be made to page 66 for further guidance on the administration of controlled assessment.

A signed authentication statement must accompany all submissions.

Detailed unit content

Approaches to solo performing

Traditional performance

A solo performance is considered to be a piece in which the student's part is undoubled and plays a significant or leading role. It is acceptable for the accompaniment to occasionally double the solo line, but excessive doubling must be avoided. Backing tracks are acceptable but the part to be assessed must not be audible as part of the backing track.

The performance may be on any instrument or voice in any style or genre. Students who play instruments for which traditional solo music is difficult to obtain may play as part of a group provided they clearly play a leading or significant role within the group.

Solo improvisation

Students can present a performance which is an improvisation based on a stimulus. The stimulus can be from any style or genre and could be a melody, rhythm, chord sequence or a visual stimulus. It can be composed by the student or provided by the class or instrumental teacher. The improvisation can be in any style or genre and does not need to be in the same style or genre as the stimulus. Some improvisational styles of performance, including those involving the passing on of music through the aural tradition, will be more suited to this performance option.

Any piece presented for moderation as a solo improvisation must be accompanied by a copy of the stimulus (in lieu of a score) either in staff notation, any other suitable notation or as an audio recording.

A traditional performance piece involving a significant element of improvisation (for example a 12-bar blues with an extended guitar solo) may be best assessed using the criteria for solo improvisation rather than those for traditional performance.

Sequenced performance

A sequenced performance is considered to be a musical item composed by someone other than the student, which has been input into a MIDI sequencer. Students' own compositions, which have been sequenced, may be presented as performances, but are considered to be realisations (see below). Teachers can provide their own arrangement of a piece as a stimulus for this task. All data input and editing must be the student's own work. In cases where the student wishes to use pre-existing loops or audio samples the piece would be considered a realisation rather than a sequenced performance.

A sequence must contain at least three individual, simultaneously sounding, independent parts.

Any program capable of capturing and manipulating MIDI information can be used for this option. Teacher-examiners should provide details of the software used for the performance.

A score or professional recording must be provided for the moderator to assess the accuracy of the performance.

Realisation

A realisation is a performance where it is not appropriate to assess accuracy using the standard accuracy descriptors. Examples of realisations include:

- sequenced compositions
- DJ performances using decks/turntables
- live electro-acoustic sound diffusions
- performances passed on by the oral tradition which do not fall under the solo improvisation or traditional performance headings
- student performances of their own compositions where it has not been appropriate to produce a score with sufficient performance detail to assess accuracy of pitch and rhythm.

Students must provide a written commentary outlining performance details and intentions in lieu of a score or professional recording. They should include as much detail as possible to allow the teacher-examiner and moderator to make a fair and accurate judgement on the quality of the performance. Pieces submitted without written commentaries will not be assessed. Teacher-examiners should make more detailed comments justifying their marking than would normally be expected when a score or professional recording is available.

Approaches to ensemble performing

Traditional performance

An ensemble performance must consist of two or more people performing undoubled, simultaneously sounding, independent parts, with or without additional backing or accompaniment as appropriate.

Where a soloist is accompanied by another instrument, such as the piano, the accompanist may submit this performance as an ensemble but the soloist may not.

Performances with other players may take place in the classroom, in centre music groups or outside of the centre but they must all be in the presence of the teacher-examiner when recording the performance that will be assessed.

The teacher-examiner must clearly indicate which part of the ensemble is to be assessed.

Ensemble improvisation

When a piece fulfils the criteria for an ensemble performance and also includes a significant element of improvisation it is considered to be an ensemble improvisation. In this case the score would be submitted as for a traditional performance along with the stimulus for the improvised sections.

Where a performance involves a significant element of improvisation from most/all of the players involved, the improvisation stimulus can be submitted in lieu of a score.

Rehearsing and directing

Students can offer rehearsing and directing as an ensemble performance. They are expected to display thorough preparation of the score and communicate effectively with the ensemble in both the rehearsal and performance stages.

The ensemble must consist of three or more performers and should not include the student.

A score of the piece to be performed along with a DVD, including the full performance and 2-5 minutes of a rehearsal, must be made available for the moderator.

Multi-track recording

Multi-track recording is considered to be a piece in which the student has been in sole charge of the recording procedure from the placement of microphones and set-up of equipment through to the recording of the ensemble to mixdown and final production of a stereo mix. It must include at least one audio track captured by the student using a microphone.

The student may act solely as engineer and producer (where they do not perform any of the live tracks), or they may perform one or more of the live tracks. Students can include an element of sequencing in their multi-track recording but they must input all sequenced data themselves.

There must be a minimum of three independent, simultaneously sounding tracks in the recording (in which any number of sequenced parts count as up to two tracks in total).

Application of the assessment criteria grids

Assessment of this unit is divided into two areas: **solo performance** and **ensemble performance**. Each performance is marked out of 30. The total marks available for this unit is 60.

Within each of the performance requirements options are available and the relevant assessment criteria grids must be applied. The options are:

Solo performing

- traditional performance
- solo improvisation
- sequenced performance
- realisation

There are **two** assessment criteria grids available for each option. One grid has a raw mark of 12 and the other 18. These should be added together to arrive at a raw mark for the whole option.

Ensemble performing

- traditional ensemble performance
- ensemble improvisation
- rehearsing and directing
- multi-track recording

There are **two** assessment criteria grids available for each option. One grid has a raw mark of 12 and the other 18. These should be added together to arrive at a raw mark for the whole option. Where multi-track recording is offered for assessment one appropriate grid from A, B or C should be selected and the raw mark added to the mark for grid D.

Levels of Difficulty grid

Assess the student's performance using the appropriate assessment criteria grids from the solo and ensemble performing options to arrive at a mark out of 30 (the raw mark).

- Assess the Level of Difficulty of the music performed using the exemplar material on pages 29-43.
- Apply the level of difficulty to the raw mark using the grid below.

Raw mark	Easier	Standard	More difficult
0	0	0	0
1	1	1	1
2	1	2	2
3	1	3	3
4	1	4	4
5	1	5	5
6	2	6	6
7	3	7	8
8	4	8	9
9	5	9	11
10	6	10	12
11	7	11	14
12	8	12	15
13	9	13	17
14	10	14	18
15	11	15	19
16	12	16	20
17	13	17	21
18	14	18	22
19	15	19	23
20	16	20	24
21	17	21	25
22	18	22	26
23	19	23	27
24	20	24	28
25	21	25	29
26	22	26	30
27	23	27	30

Solo performing – traditional performance

Accuracy (of pitch and rhythm)

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The performance is accurate and fluent. Any slips are inconsequential. Intonation is secure.	11-12
	Good	The performance is mainly accurate and fluent. There are only occasional small slips. Intonation is mostly secure.	9-10
	Competent	The performance is broadly accurate and fluent although errors may interrupt the flow. Intonation is often secure.	6-8
	Basic	Accuracy is only achieved in the more straightforward passages. Fluency is repeatedly affected by errors. Intonation is insecure.	3-5
	Limited	Accuracy and fluency are only occasionally evident. Intonation is poor throughout.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

An appropriate stimulus must be supplied to allow assessment of accuracy for both pitch and rhythm.

Interpretation

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing and stylish performance. A secure sense of style with detailed attention to articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	15-18
	Good	A good performance which has a clear, but perhaps not always convincing, sense of style. The music is well conveyed and opportunities are taken to shape the music with articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful performance – an awareness of style is displayed during some expressive passages. There is some shaping of the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate performance demonstrating a basic awareness of style with few attempts to shape the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	4-6
	Limited	The performance demonstrates no conscious sense of style, displaying little understanding of how to shape the music through articulation, phrasing or dynamic contrast.	1-3

Solo performing – solo improvisation

Use of the stimulus/fluency

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The stimulus is exploited with complete fluency and imagination showing contrast, development, a sound sense of structure and the potential of the instrument. Intonation is secure.	11-12
	Good	The stimulus is exploited with considerable fluency and imagination, showing contrast, development, sense of structure and awareness of the potential of the instrument. Intonation is mostly secure.	9-10
	Competent	Exploitation of the stimulus demonstrating some aspects of fluency and imagination, showing contrast, development, sense of structure and awareness of the potential of the instrument. Intonation is often secure.	6-8
	Basic	The response to the stimulus lacks any exploitation of the original idea. It is affected by excessive repetition, hesitancy and shows little sense of structure and minimal awareness of the potential of the instrument. Intonation is insecure.	3-5
	Limited	The stimulus is largely ignored. Intonation is poor throughout.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

The stimulus used for the improvisation (ie melodic or rhythmic motif or chord progression) must be supplied to allow assessment of its use in the improvisation.

Interpretation

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing and stylish performance demonstrating a secure sense of style with detailed attention to articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	15-18
	Good	A good performance which has a clear, but perhaps not always convincing, sense of style. The meaning of the music is adequately conveyed and most opportunities are taken to shape the music with articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful performance. There is some awareness of style displayed during some expressive passages. There is some shaping of the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate performance demonstrating a basic awareness of style with only a few attempts to shape the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast.	4-6
	Limited	The performance demonstrates no conscious sense of style and displays little understanding of how to shape the music through articulation, phrasing or dynamic contrast.	1-3

Solo performing – sequenced performance

Accuracy (of pitch and rhythm)

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	An excellent performance in which any slips are inconsequential.	11-12
	Good	The performance demonstrates only occasional, small slips which do not detract from the performance.	9-10
	Competent	The performance demonstrates some noticeable errors, which detract from the performance.	6-8
	Basic	The performance demonstrates significant, intrusive errors but accuracy is achieved in the more straightforward passages.	3-5
	Limited	The performance is accurate only occasionally and there is no attention to accuracy of note input.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

An appropriate stimulus must be supplied to allow assessment of accuracy for both pitch and rhythm. If the piece to be submitted is a sequenced performance of a student's own composition then the realisation marking grid should be used.

Interpretation — (1 Articulation and phrasing, 2 Dynamics, 3 Timbre, 4 Panning)

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing and stylish performance demonstrating detailed attention to the four areas of interpretation. Dynamics have been shaped in addition to essential dynamic contrasts.	15-18
	Good	A good performance demonstrating that attention has been given to all four areas to produce a musically satisfying sequence with a sense of style.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful performance demonstrating that some attention has been given to three of the four areas with some sense of style.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate performance demonstrating some attention has been given to two of the four areas with some sense of style.	4-6
	Limited	A performance demonstrating little evidence of attention to musical detail or style.	1-3
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

Solo performing – realisation

Fluency and control of technical demands

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The performance is fluent throughout displaying excellent control of the technical demands of the style.	11-12
	Good	The performance is fluent displaying good control of the technical demands of the style.	9-10
	Competent	The performance displays some control of the technical demands of the style, although there may be some lack of fluency.	6-8
	Basic	Only the more straightforward elements of the performance are achieved with any degree of fluency. Few of the technical demands are met.	3-5
	Limited	None of the technical demands of the performance have been met with any degree of satisfaction.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

Interpretation

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing and stylish performance that displays control of all aspects of interpretation appropriate to the style.	15-18
	Good	A good performance that displays control of most interpretative detail as appropriate to the style.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful performance that displays control of some of the interpretative detail as appropriate to the style.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate performance that displays control of little of the interpretative detail as appropriate to the style.	4-6
	Limited	A performance displaying little or no control over any aspects of interpretative detail or any interpretative detail is inappropriate to the style.	1-3
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

Refer to the *Realisation* section on page 11 for details on the written commentary to be submitted with this performance.

■ ■ Ensemble performing – traditional ensemble performance

Accuracy (of pitch and rhythm)

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The performance is accurate and fluent. Any slips are inconsequential. Intonation is secure.	11-12
	Good	The performance is mainly accurate and fluent. There are only occasional small slips. Intonation is mostly secure.	9-10
	Competent	The performance is broadly accurate and fluent although errors may interrupt the flow. Intonation is often secure.	6-8
	Basic	Accuracy is only achieved in the more straightforward passages. Fluency is repeatedly affected by errors. Intonation is insecure.	3-5
	Limited	Accuracy and fluency are only occasionally evident. Intonation is poor throughout.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

An appropriate stimulus must be supplied to allow assessment of accuracy for both pitch and rhythm.

Interpretation and ensemble skill

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing performance demonstrating a secure sense of style with detailed attention to articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. The performance demonstrates reaction and adjustment to other parts and displays an excellent awareness of balance throughout.	15-18
	Good	A performance which has a clear, but not always convincing sense of style. The music is well conveyed and opportunities are taken to shape the music with articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. There is generally good reaction and adjustment to other parts and the performance displays a good awareness of balance throughout.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful performance demonstrating awareness of style during some expressive passages. There is some shaping of the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. There is occasional difficulty in reacting and adjusting to other parts although there is some awareness of balance.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate performance demonstrating a basic awareness of style with few attempts to shape the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. There is evidence of difficulty in reacting and adjusting to other parts and little awareness of balance throughout.	4-6
	Limited	The performance demonstrates no conscious sense of style and only scant understanding of how to shape the music through articulation, phrasing or dynamic contrast. The performance displays little or no understanding of the demands of an ensemble performance.	1-3
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

■ Ensemble performing – ensemble improvisation

Use of the stimulus/fluency

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The stimulus is exploited with complete fluency and imagination showing contrast, development, a sound sense of structure and the potential of the instrument. Intonation is secure.	11-12
	Good	The stimulus is exploited with considerable fluency and imagination, showing contrast, development, sense of structure and awareness of the potential of the instrument. Intonation is mostly secure.	9-10
	Competent	Exploitation of the stimulus demonstrating some aspects of fluency and imagination, showing contrast, development, sense of structure and awareness of the potential of the instrument. Intonation is often secure.	6-8
	Basic	The response to the stimulus lacks exploitation of the original idea. It is affected by excessive repetition, hesitancy, little sense of structure and minimal awareness of the potential of the instrument. Intonation is insecure.	3-5
	Limited	The stimulus is largely ignored. Intonation is poor throughout.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

The stimulus used for the improvisation (ie melodic or rhythmic motif or chord progression) must be supplied to allow assessment of its use in the improvisation.

Interpretation and ensemble skill

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing performance demonstrating a secure sense of style with detailed attention to articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. The performance demonstrates reaction and adjustment to other parts and displays an excellent awareness of balance throughout.	15-18
	Good	A performance which has a clear, but not always convincing sense of style. The music is well conveyed and opportunities are taken to shape the music with articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. There is generally good reaction and adjustment to other parts and the performance displays a good awareness of balance throughout.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful performance demonstrating awareness of style during some expressive passages. There is some shaping of the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. There is occasional difficulty in reacting and adjusting to other parts although there is some awareness of balance.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate performance demonstrating a basic awareness of style with few attempts to shape the music through articulation, phrasing and dynamic contrast. There is evidence of difficulty in reacting and adjusting to other parts and little awareness of balance throughout.	4-6
	Limited	The performance demonstrates no conscious sense of style and only scant understanding of how to shape the music through articulation, phrasing or dynamic contrast. The performance displays little or no understanding of the demands of an ensemble performance.	1-3
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

Ensemble performing – rehearsing and directing

Preparation

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The performance is well rehearsed after thoughtful preparation, exhibiting detailed knowledge of the score.	11-12
	Good	The performance is well rehearsed, exhibiting reasonable preparation of the score.	9-10
	Competent	The performance demonstrates some evidence of rehearsal with some preparation of the score.	6-8
	Basic	The performance is poorly rehearsed with scant attention to preparation of the score.	3-5
	Limited	The performance demonstrates little or no evidence of any rehearsal or preparation of the score.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

An appropriate score must be provided for moderation purposes.

Interpretation and ensemble skill

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The performance displays an authoritative approach, eliciting an excellent response from the performers. The correct tempo is clearly indicated with a precise beat. There is positive and sensitive control of the entries and interplay between the parts and of all performance details. A secure, stylish and idiomatic performance is achieved with an excellent awareness of balance and tonal quality.	15-18
	Good	The performance displays a confident approach, eliciting an effective response from the performers. The correct tempo is indicated although the beat is not fully precise. The entries and interplay between the parts are well controlled and performance details generally well executed. The overall performance is generally stylish and reflects a good awareness of balance and tonal quality.	11-14
	Competent	The beat given is occasionally variable eliciting a less confident response from the performers. Control of the entries is present but not always decisive. Some of the performance details are observed. There is some awareness of balance and style.	7-10
	Basic	The beat given is often variable eliciting a less confident response from the performers. Control of the entries is present but rarely decisive. Some of the performance details are observed. There is scant awareness of balance and style.	4-6
	Limited	The beat given is significantly variable eliciting an unsure response from the performers. Control of entries is seldom displayed and few of the performance details are observed. There is little awareness of balance and style.	1-3
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

Ensemble performing – multi-track recording

The assessment grid used to mark multi-track recording depends on the student's role in the recording. Choose grid A, B or C as appropriate. All multi-track recordings should be marked using grid D in addition to one of grids A, B or C.

A

Multi-track recording where the student has performed one or more of the live tracks

Accuracy (mark the best live track performed by the student)

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The playing is accurate and fluent and any slips are inconsequential.	11-12
	Good	The playing is mainly accurate and fluent displaying only occasional small slips.	9-10
	Competent	The playing is broadly accurate but there are some small blemishes which interrupt the flow.	6-8
	Basic	The playing displays that accuracy is achieved in the more straightforward passages. At times the accuracy of the music may be achieved at the expense of fluency and tempo.	3-5
	Limited	The playing displays little accuracy.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

B Multi-track recording where the student has not performed any of the live tracks

Directing skills/unity of ensemble

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	The recording displays an accurate, musical performance. All tracks are in time and complement each other well.	11-12
	Good	The recording is mainly accurate with only occasional small slips. The ensemble between tracks is mainly successful.	9-10
	Competent	The recording displays some blemishes which detract from the overall performance. There is occasional loss of ensemble between tracks.	6-8
	Basic	The recording displays significant, intrusive errors in performance. The unity of ensemble is only evident in straightforward passages.	3-5
	Limited	The recording displays accuracy in performance only occasionally. The tracks are out of time with each other.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

C Multi-track recording which mixes sequencing and recording (all sequenced tracks must have been input by the student)

Accuracy (of pitch and rhythm in sequenced track(s))

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	Excellent – any slips are inconsequential.	11-12
	Good	Occasional, small slips which do not detract from the performance.	9-10
	Competent	Some noticeable errors, which detract from the performance.	6-8
	Basic	Significant, intrusive errors evident, but accuracy is achieved in the more straightforward passages.	3-5
	Limited	Accuracy is only occasionally evident/no attention to accuracy of note input.	1-2
	Unachieved	There is no rewardable material.	0

See page 28 for assessment criteria grid D.

D

Recording skills – all multi-track recordings must be assessed using this grid in addition to one of grids A, B or C

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark range
AO1	Excellent	A convincing, musical recording. Balance/stereo: all tracks are well balanced and good use has been made of the stereo field. EQ: the full frequency range has been utilised through judicious use of EQ. Signal to noise: good signal to noise ratio. No distortion or other noise. FX: appropriate and well controlled – adds to the recording.	15-18
	Good	A good recording, but one or two of the following detract slightly from the overall quality. Balance/stereo: one of the tracks is overbearing or very quiet/restricted stereo width. EQ: one of the tracks is poorly EQed/slight overall problem (eg lack of brightness/too harsh or boomy). Signal to noise: some noticeable hiss or occasional noise/distortion, but not overly intrusive. FX: slightly overdone/some tracks too dry.	11-14
	Competent	A generally successful recording, but three or four of the following detract from the overall quality. Balance/stereo: one of the tracks is overbearing or very quiet/restricted stereo width. EQ: one of the tracks is poorly EQed/slight overall problem (eg lack of brightness/too harsh or boomy). Signal to noise: some noticeable hiss or occasional noise/distortion, but not overly intrusive. FX: slightly overdone/some tracks too dry.	7-10
	Basic	An adequate recording, but one or two of the following significantly detract from the overall quality. Balance/stereo: muddy mix/serious problems with two or more tracks/no use of panning. EQ: two or more tracks poorly EQed/serious overall restriction of frequency range (eg very bassy or trebly recording). Signal to noise: very hissy or occasional intrusive noise. FX: inappropriately overdone or none used at all.	4-6
	Limited	A basic recording – little attention has been given to any of the four areas. For example, all panned to one side/some instruments can't be heard at all/extremely quiet recording.	1-3

Levels of Difficulty for instruments, voice and sequencing

It is not possible to provide examples for all instruments. The following pages should be used as general guidance.

A 'best fit' approach should be used when determining in which Level of Difficulty (LoD) a piece falls. A piece may be considered to be more difficult if it fulfills five or more of the more difficult criteria and the rest are standard. If one criterion is felt to be easier and another is more difficult they would average out as two standard criteria.

Voice

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Mainly conjunct melody	Some leaps	Some awkward intervals
Pitch range less than one octave	Pitch range between an octave and a 10th	Pitch range greater than a 10th
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
No long, sustained phrases. Regular phrasing throughout	Phrases not all the same length requiring some breath control	Some long, sustained phrases requiring good breath control
Syllabic throughout	Mainly syllabic with some simple melismas	Several melismatic sections and/or fast passages requiring clear enunciation
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	Some variety of articulation including some slurs/staccato/accents	A range of articulation required
No modulations	Modulation to closely related key	More than one modulation or modulation to more distant key
Accompaniment supports voice throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with accompaniment	Solo line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Piano

Easier	Standard	More difficult
One hand only/hands in octaves throughout	Two hands with some independence	Both hands fairly independent
C major/A minor or simple pentatonic	Key signatures of one or two sharps/flats	Key signatures of three or more sharps/flats or modal/chromatic/atonal
No accidentals	Occasional, logical accidentals	Frequent accidentals
5-finger position	Some changes of hand position	Frequent changes of hand position
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo	Moderate/moderately fast tempo and/or some gradation of tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	Some variety of articulation including some slurs/staccato/accents	A range of articulation required
No modulations	Modulation to closely related key	More than one modulation or modulation to more distant key

Keyboard

Easier	Standard	More difficult
One hand only/hands in octaves throughout	Two hands with some independence	Both hands fairly independent
No chordal accompaniment	Simple fingered chords/single fingered chords	Wider range of chords (not single fingered)
C major/A minor or simple pentatonic	Key signatures of one or two sharps/flats	Key signatures of three or more sharps/flats or modal/chromatic/ atonal
5-finger position	Some changes of hand position	Frequent changes of hand position
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts/touch sensitivity function turned off	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required or no registration changes	Some variety of articulation including some slurs/staccato/ accents	A range of articulation required/ use of appropriate registration changes
No modulations	Modulation to closely related key	More than one modulation or modulation to more distant key

Electric guitar

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Pitch range covers three strings	Pitch range covers four or more strings	Pitch range covers all six strings
All in one position	Includes infrequent position changes	Requires frequent position shifts/ covers range up to or above 12th fret
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required (no hammer-ons, pull-offs, slides or bends)	Some variety of articulation including some hammer-ons, pull-offs, slides or bends	A range of articulation required, possibly including some palm muting or use of tremolo arm
Easy key for the instrument	A key which allows less use of open strings	Harder key for the instrument
Simple picking throughout	A range of picking required, perhaps changing from chords to single notes	Some more intricate picking techniques required
Supported by accompaniment throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with accompaniment	Solo line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Acoustic guitar

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Easy chord shapes	Some barre chords	Frequent barre chords/some awkward chord changes/some altered or extended chords used
All in one position	Includes infrequent position changes	Requires frequent position shifts/covers range up to or above 12th fret
Simple strumming pattern with little variety	Undemanding but varied strumming pattern/more complex but repetitive pattern	Challenging rhythmic accompaniment pattern
Regular, infrequent chord changes	Chord changes not always regular/more frequent chord changes	Irregular chord changes/some fast chord changes
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	Some variety of articulation required	Some string dampening required/a range of articulation
No modulations	Modulation to closely related key	More than one modulation or modulation to more distant key
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Solo line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Classical guitar

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Monophonic melody	Bass notes (which could be open strings) sounding along with melody	Independent melody and bass parts
All in one position	Includes infrequent position changes	Requires frequent position shifts/ covers range up to or above 12th fret
Simple plucking techniques required	Some variety required in right-hand technique	Includes some more intricate right-hand techniques
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required (no hammer-ons, pull-offs, slides or bends)	Some variety of articulation including some hammer-ons, pull-offs, slides and possibly some string dampening	Some string dampening required/ a range of articulation
Easy key for the instrument	A key which allows less use of open strings	Harder key for the instrument
No chords used	Mostly simple chord shapes	Frequent barre chords/some awkward chord changes

Bass guitar

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Bass line made up mostly of root notes	Bass line contains a variety of chord tones	Bass line more complex
All in one position	Includes infrequent position changes	Requires frequent position shifts/ covers range up to or above 12th fret
Mostly crotchet movement	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required (no hammer-ons, pull-offs, slides or bends)	Some variety of articulation including some hammer-ons, pull-offs, and slides	A range of articulation required
Easy key for the instrument	A key which allows less use of open strings	Harder key for the instrument
No modulations	Modulation to closely related key	More than one modulation or modulation to more distant key
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Bass line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Drumkit

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Simple rhythmic patterns	Wider range of rhythmic patterns	More complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	A variety of articulation and phrasing required	Detailed phrasing and articulation required
Includes few fills	Simple fills more frequent	Detailed fills required
Little left foot control required (hi-hat)	Some left foot control required	Good left foot control required
2/4, 4/4 metre	Compound time, 3/4 metre	Unusual metre/includes changes of metre
Requires co-ordination between hands and feet	Requires limited independence between limbs	Requires independence between limbs
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Significant rhythmic independence within ensemble

Strings

Easier	Standard	More difficult
All in first position	Requires changes of position	Requires more frequent position shifts
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	Some variety of articulation including some slurs/staccato/accents	A range of articulation required
Limited bowing technique required	More co-ordination required between left hand and bow	A range of bowing techniques required (possibly including quick changes between pizz. and arco)
Easy key for the instrument	A key which allows less use of open strings	Harder key for the instrument
No modulations	Modulation to closely related key	More than one modulation or modulation to more distant key
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Solo line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Woodwind

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Pitch range of an octave or less	Pitch range of up to a 12th	Pitch range of more than a 12th
Mainly conjunct melody/in an easy register for the instrument	Some leaps, moving out of the easy register for the instrument	Some awkward intervals and use of the full register of the instrument
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	Some variety of articulation including some slurs/staccato/accents	A range of articulation required
No long, sustained phrases. Regular phrasing throughout	Phrases not all the same length requiring some breath control	Some long, sustained phrases requiring good breath control
Easy key for the instrument	Slightly more difficult key for the instrument	Harder key for the instrument
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Solo line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Brass

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Pitch range of an octave or less	Pitch range of up to a 12th	Pitch range of more than a 12th
Mainly conjunct melody/in an easy register for the instrument	Some leaps, moving out of the easy register for the instrument, includes several low notes	Some awkward intervals and use of the full register of the instrument
Restricted range of rhythmic patterns	Some variation in rhythmic patterns	Some complex rhythmic patterns
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	Some variety of articulation including some slurs/staccato/accents	A range of articulation required
Frequent rests	Some thought required to ensure breathing is appropriate	Requires paced breathing to maintain control
No long, sustained phrases. Regular phrasing throughout	Phrases not all the same length requiring some breath control	Some long, sustained phrases requiring good breath control
Easy key for the instrument	Slightly more difficult key for the instrument, requiring more use of valves/slide positions	Harder key for the instrument, requiring more dexterity in use of valves/slide
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Solo line often exposed/much interplay between parts

Melodic percussion (for example xylophone / marimba)

Easier	Standard	More difficult
No double strokes or damping required	Single stroke rolls/some damping required	Includes some chords/frequent damping required
Mainly conjunct melody	Some more awkward intervals	Frequent leaps and awkward intervals
Simple rhythmic patterns	Wider range of rhythmic patterns	More complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Limited articulation required	A variety of articulation and phrasing required	Detailed phrasing and articulation required
2/4, 4/4 metre	Compound time, 3/4 metre	Unusual metre/includes changes of metre
C major/A minor or simple pentatonic	Key signatures of one or two sharps/flats	Key signatures of three or more sharps/flats or modal/chromatic/atonal
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Significant independence within ensemble/much interplay between parts

Snare drum

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Simple rhythmic patterns	Wider range of rhythmic patterns	More complex rhythmic patterns
Slow/moderate tempo. No tempo changes	Moderate/moderately fast tempo	Fast tempo requiring some dexterity and/or occasional tempo changes
Limited opportunity for dynamic contrasts	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
No dynamic variation	Limited range of dynamics	Wide range of dynamics
Limited articulation required	A variety of articulation and phrasing required	Detailed phrasing and articulation required
No rolls	Some straightforward rolls	Frequent rolls
No decorations	Flams and paradiddles required	Flams, paradiddles, drags and ruffs required
2/4, 4/4 metre	Compound time, 3/4 metre	Unusual metre/includes changes of metre
Supported by other parts throughout	Occasional exposed entries/some interplay with other parts	Significant rhythmic independence within ensemble

Sequencing

Easier	Standard	More difficult
Three independent parts	Four independent parts	Five or more independent parts
Treble or bass clef only	Treble and bass clef	Treble, bass clef and an additional clef (including octave transpositions of bass/treble clef eg double bass) or tablature
No accidentals	Key signatures with one sharp or flat	Key signatures with three or more sharps or flats
4/4 metre	2/4, 3/4 or 6/8 metre	An unusual metre or requiring changes of metre
Steady tempo throughout	Requires a change of tempo	More than one tempo change/ gradation of tempo
No dynamic variation	Some general dynamic contrasts	General dynamic contrasts including some gradation of dynamics
Much repetition and/or doubling	Some repetition and/or doubling	Little/no repetition and/or doubling
Up to 24 bars	25-32 bars	33 bars or more
Simple rhythms and note values throughout	Wider range of rhythmic patterns	More complex rhythmic patterns

Levels of Difficulty for other performing options

Improvisation

Improvisations should be awarded a Level of Difficulty (LoD) according to the outcome: the final recorded performance should be judged against the appropriate set of criteria for the instrument in question.

Realisation

Realisations will normally be standard difficulty level unless the student demonstrates a particularly basic example of the genre (in which case it will be judged as easier) or a particularly involved, complex performance (when it will be judged as more difficult).

Multi-track recording

A. Where the student has performed one or more of the live tracks, the whole performance should have the same LoD as that which would be applied to the part assessed for accuracy.

B. Where the student has not performed any of the live tracks, the recording should always be assessed as standard, unless there is clear evidence that the demands of the task were well beyond the minimum specification requirements (when it will be judged as more difficult).

C. If a recording mixes sequencing and recording, the whole performance will have the same LoD as that which would be applied to the sequencing element.

Rehearsing and directing

Rehearsing and directing performances should be assessed as standard.